

Putting down roots

Roots do two things: they anchor plants and keep them secure, and they absorb water and food. Some roots have weird and wonderful ways of doing this!



Far out

Roots can only grow where there is water. Tree roots near the surface grow outwards, up to four times the width of the tree. Other roots can dig down deep enough to break through sewers.

Stuck in the mud

Mangroves live in swamps. Their huge prop roots support the stems to stop them being washed away. The tangled roots also trap mud, which has nutrients for the tree.

Storage system

Not everything underground is a root. Bulbs are food storage systems that contain the leaves and stems of new plants. When the plant grows, the roots descend.

